



ENRICH THE COUNTRY, STRENGTHEN THE MILITARY

THE MEIJI RESTORATION (1868)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Modernizing Japan

BEFORE

1853 A US naval force arrives in Japan and demands trading links.

1854–1855 The US, Britain, the Netherlands, and Russia force trading treaties on Japan.

1866 The rulers of the Choshu and Satsuma regions form a secret alliance against the ruling Tokugawa shogunate.

1867 The Tokugawa shogunate ends.

AFTER

1868–1869 Defenders of the shogunate are defeated.

1871 Feudalism is abolished, and Japan launches a far-reaching program of reform.

1894–1895 The Sino-Japanese War underlines expansionist Japanese aims in the region.

1904–1905 The Russo-Japanese War ends in Japanese victory.

The overthrow in 1868 of the Tokugawa shogunate, rulers of Japan for 250 years, was led by feudal barons from the southern provinces of Choshu and Satsuma and was the direct consequence of its weakness in the face of

Aggressive Western demands for trading rights in Japan highlight the **weakness of its ruling elite.**

Leading feudal barons reassert the authority of the boy emperor Meiji and oust the shogunate.

The barons see the adoption of Western political and social methods as the best way to **strengthen Japan.**

Military might is seen as an essential way of fulfilling Japanese ambitions.

Modernization and Westernization encapsulate the Meiji period, and Japan emerges as an **imperial power.**

aggressive demands by the United States, Britain, Russia, and the Netherlands to establish trading links. In place of the shoguns, the pliant 14-year-old Meiji emperor would “exercise supreme authority.” The goal of the barons was not to take over and maintain Japan as it had existed under the shogunate—rigidly hierarchical and deliberately isolated from the wider world. Rather, it was that they felt Japan’s clear destiny could only be established by the